parliamentary constituencies. By the end of 2020, it had emerged as the second pole of politics in its new catchment areas of West Bengal and Odisha in the east, turned into the dominant national party in most of the north-eastern states and was growing fast in Telangana as well as Andhra Pradesh. It was also looking to expand in Kerala and using alliances to gain a foothold in Tamil Nadu.

Many opponents of the party have convinced themselves that Modi's special appeal is a black-swan event. When it goes away, the BJP will collapse. This is wishful thinking. Scholarship around the BJP has so far failed to account for its structural growth at the micro-level. Even the most thoughtful scholars studying it continue to squabble over whether the BJP has only 'built an election machine' or a real 'system' like the Congress before it.[76] Academics can continue to squabble over definitions of what constitutes a political system. The fact is that you cannot switch a party machinery off and on with the press of a button. People and voters are not galvanised like that. The new BJP's 'election machine' is built on a system that works all year round at the district level. This is precisely why it works at election time.

To be clear: the BJP's 303 seats (with 37.36 per cent votes) in the 2019 Lok Sabha constituted the largest majority in Parliament in over three-and-a-half decades. It ranked next to Rajiv Gandhi's 404 (49.1 per cent votes) seats in 1984, Indira Gandhi's 352 seats (43.6 per cent votes) in 1971 and Nehru's 361 tally (44.7 per cent votes) in 1962. To be sure, the Congress won greater vote shares in all those elections than Modi's BJP. But it is not with the 1970s or 1980s Congress that the new BJP must be compared. The 1980s Congress was already in deep decline as a system of power. Also, the earlier Congress victories occurred in a different era and in a vastly different political domain from post-1980s India, which saw the rise of caste-based and regional parties in most states. They also occurred in a world before the internet, digital connectivity and new information systems, and in a polity that was powered by older patterns of local patronage. The BJP's election triumphs under Modi have come in a vastly reordered and digitally connected society. And yet, the BJP's political dominance today is actually more akin to the Congress of